

# Sundowning Calm-Down Routine

Reduce evening agitation. Create calm. Promote comfort.

"I feel confused as the day gets late."

## SUPPLIES NEEDED

- Soft music or nature sounds
- Dim lamps or string lights
- Comfort item — blanket, pillow, photo
- Familiar activity — folding, sensory items
- Lotion or hand massager (optional)
- Comfortable seating
- Water or a warm drink
- Clock or timer, for the routine

## DIRECTIONS — KEEP SIMPLE

- 1 Start slowing down 1–2 hours before sundown.
- 2 Lower lights and reduce noise and clutter.
- 3 Offer a calming activity or comfort item.
- 4 Speak slowly and gently, in short sentences.
- 5 Stay present and reassuring — don't rush or correct.
- 6 Help them transition to rest. Praise their effort.

## SETUP

- 1 Dim the lights, close blinds if needed.
- 2 Turn on soft, soothing music.
- 3 Remove extra noise — TV, loud talk.
- 4 Prepare a calm activity and comfort item.
- 5 Offer a drink or snack if appropriate.

## ACTIVITY OPTIONS

- Music — tap or clap together, slow tempo
- Fold towels or washcloths
- Look through a photo album or magazine
- Hand massage or apply lotion
- Color or draw simple pictures
- Look out the window and talk about what you see
- Read a short story or picture book

## WHAT TO WATCH FOR

- **Increased confusion** — simplify task & environment
- **Irritability** — lower your voice, offer comfort
- **Restlessness** — offer gentle movement
- **Fatigue** — transition to rest, seated activity
- **Refusing activity** — offer a different choice

## CUES FOR STAFF

- Keep voice calm, low, and steady
- Avoid too many questions or instructions
- Don't take words or behavior personally
- Validate feelings first, then redirect
- Stay consistent with the evening routine

*"It's getting late. Let's relax together." · "You're safe. I'm right here." · "Let's sit and listen to some music."*

## BENEFITS

- Reduces evening agitation & anxiety
- Promotes relaxation, better sleep
- Builds security and trust

## ADAPTATIONS

- Start the routine earlier
- Shorten if attention fades
- Offer one-on-one time

## DID YOU KNOW?

Sundowning often links to light changes, fatigue, overstimulation, or unmet needs. A calm, predictable routine helps the brain feel safe.

## FUN FACTS

- Dim lighting can lower anxiety
- Soft music can lower stress hormones
- Routine helps the brain feel secure

*"Your calm, kind presence is the greatest gift you can give during the most challenging times."*

Response: ☐ Calm ☐ Neutral ☐ Agitated

Staff Initials: \_\_\_\_\_ Time: \_\_\_\_\_